

Academy Source and Reference Guide

Work–Life Balance and Communication Skills • Prepared August 19, 2026

Purpose. This guide identifies the principal public resources and foundational texts used to support the concepts taught in the two Academy courses. The Academy's wording, multiple-choice activities, scoring logic, browser-based workbook, summaries, and workplace scenarios were developed specifically for Homes for the Brave. The courses are educational tools—not clinical or psychological assessments.

Academy website: [Homes for the Brave Vocational Services Academy](#)

Part I — Work–Life Balance Sources

1. The Surgeon General's Framework for Workplace Mental Health and Well-Being

U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (2022; reviewed 2025). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports work–life harmony, autonomy, flexibility, connection, worker voice, and the relationship between workplace conditions and well-being.

2. Mental Health at Work

World Health Organization (2024). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports discussion of excessive workload, inflexible hours, unclear roles, limited support, home/work conflict, and workplace mental-health protection.

3. About Stress at Work

CDC / National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (2024). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports the definition of job stress and the importance of matching job demands with a worker's capabilities, resources, and needs.

4. Quality of Worklife Questionnaire

CDC / National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (2026). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Informed the course's self-reflection approach to workload, autonomy, scheduling, job satisfaction, stress, and worker well-being. Academy questions are original and are not the NIOSH instrument.

5. Work Flexibility and Worker Well-Being: Evidence from the United States

CDC / National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (2022). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports discussion of scheduling, time off, work–family balance, job stress, and job satisfaction.

6. Build Your Personal Health Plan

U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs, Whole Health (2026). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports identifying what matters most, rating life areas, choosing priorities, and creating a personal plan.

7. How to Set a SMART Goal

U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs, Whole Health Library (2025). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports breaking broad goals into specific, measurable, action-oriented, realistic, and timed steps.

8. Managing Stress

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (2026). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports healthy coping strategies, sleep, physical activity, relaxation, gratitude, social connection, and seeking appropriate support.

9. About Sleep

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (2024). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports sleep as part of energy, mood, attention, memory, stress reduction, and day-to-day functioning.

10. Physical Activity Guidelines for Americans — Current Guidelines

U.S. Office of Disease Prevention and Health Promotion (updated 2025). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports movement and physical activity as components of physical and emotional well-being.

Part II — Communication Skills Sources

1. Personal Styles & Effective Performance

David W. Merrill and Roger H. Reid / Routledge (1981). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Foundational source for the four social-style framework and the principle that there is no single best style. The Academy uses accessible labels: Direct (adapted from Driving), Analytical, Supportive (adapted from Amiable), and Expressive.

2. Assert Yourself! Workbook

Centre for Clinical Interventions, Government of Western Australia (educational workbook). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports the distinction among passive, aggressive, and assertive behavior and provides a step-by-step educational approach to assertiveness practice.

3. Module 1: Communication and Assertiveness

Oxford University Press, Treatments That Work series (2010). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports teaching passive, aggressive, passive-aggressive, and assertive styles; active listening; self-expression; and obstacles to assertiveness.

4. Improve Your Emotional Well-Being

Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (2024). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports calm and respectful tone, honest expression, “I” statements, active listening, empathy, relationship building, and social connection.

5. Communication and Coordination for Host Employers, Contractors, and Staffing Agencies

Occupational Safety and Health Administration (current web guidance). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports clear exchange of workplace information, reporting concerns to the correct person, coordinating responsibilities, and communicating when conditions change.

6. Worker Participation

Occupational Safety and Health Administration (current web guidance). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports speaking up, worker input, access to information, collaboration, and participation in workplace problem-solving.

7. Mental Health at Work

World Health Organization (2024). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Supports open communication, active listening, interpersonal skills, worker training, and managing psychosocial risks at work.

8. Communication Principles

Toronto Academic Pain Medicine Institute (current educational guidance). [Open source](#)

Course connection: Provides concise descriptions of passive, aggressive, passive-aggressive, and assertive communication and examples of respectful assertive behavior.

How the Academy Adapted These Sources

- The communication-preference assessment uses original statements written for workplace learning. It is not the proprietary SOCIAL STYLE Profile and is not a validated psychological instrument.
- “Direct” and “Supportive” were selected as plain-language, strengths-based alternatives to “Driving” and “Amiable.”
- The relationship-match guidance is educational. It describes likely communication friction—not compatibility, personality, character, or whether two people will like one another.
- The workplace scenarios, answer choices, scoring, summary language, browser storage, and downloadable workbook were created for the Homes for the Brave Vocational Services Academy.
- Participants are encouraged to use assertive communication—clear, calm, direct, and respectful—while adapting delivery to the needs of different communication preferences.

Recommended Citation for the Academy

Homes for the Brave. (2026). Vocational Services Academy: Finding Work–Life Balance and Communication Skills at Work [Interactive educational website]. <https://bellowsed-bit.github.io/hftb-vocational-academy/>